Community Stabilization Unit - Early Recovery Initiative

Community Atmospheric Panels

SABID/ANOLE

SOUTHWEST STATE OF SOMALIA | MARCH 2026

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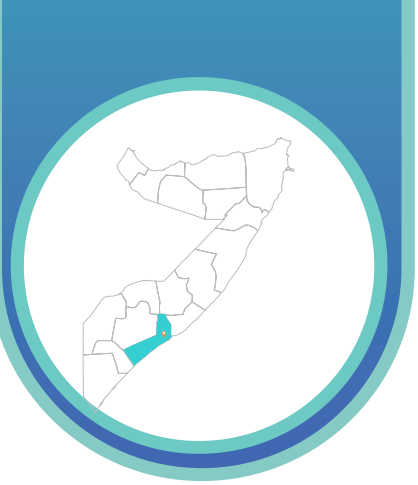

CAPs

Areas of focus

Living conditions

Recovery initiatives

Governance

Security

Justice

Media

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This report presents the findings of a Community Atmospheric Panels (CAPs) assessment conducted in the Sabid (Sabiid) and Anole (Caanoole) villages in the Southwest State of Somalia during the last week of November 2025. The assessment examined living conditions, recovery prospects, security dynamics, governance structures, access to justice, media use, and community perceptions of security actors.

Living conditions for returnees are very poor. Families with partially damaged homes have cleared debris and built makeshift shelters from plastic sheeting, often shared by three to seven families, while others remain displaced. Most assets were destroyed during the conflict. The situation worsens with the closure of the rehabilitated bridge linking Sabid and Anole to Afgoye and Awdhegle. Although repaired by TURKSOM in October 2025, the bridge remains inaccessible for security reasons, limiting mobility, market access, and transport, and preventing families from retrieving or replacing assets. The conflict also severely impacted livelihoods. Farming, the main source of income before, is constrained by restricted access to about 120 hectares of land, damaged irrigation systems, limited inputs, and early river drying during the Deyr season. A petty trade has collapsed, and there is no market access, deepening economic vulnerability. Explosive remnants in residential and farmland areas pose serious risks to civilians trying to clean and resettle.

Local governance remains dominated by traditional clan systems. While relations are generally good, women and youth have little decision-making power. Engagement with the Federal Government of Somalia (FGS) is limited, mainly concerning service delivery. Communities are uncertain about government support beyond security. No political rivalries are reported, as residents focus on recovery. Access to justice is limited by destroyed institutions and a lack of police, with communities relying on the traditional Xeer system and on elder councils trusted with social order and dispute resolution.

Despite widespread destruction, community resilience remains strong, with residents supporting one another through shelter provision, debris removal, and small-scale reconstruction. However, since the villages' liberation in August 2025, humanitarian aid has been minimal, aside from bridge repairs. Internally displaced persons (IDPs) from Sabid and Anole in Marerey and Afgoye face severe hardship, relying on aid, casual labour, or begging, with climate stress heightening food insecurity.

Social and Economic Challenges

- Market isolation
- Shelter shortages
- Food insecurity
- Destroyed livelihoods

Governance and Security Challenges

- Clan dominance
- Limited inclusion
- Recovery insecurity

The CAP revealed a gap between security improvements and civilian recovery. Without urgent, coordinated efforts covering shelter, water, livelihoods, infrastructure, policing, and IDP support, Sabid and Anole risk prolonged displacement, worsening poverty, and instability. Government, humanitarian, and community efforts are vital for peace and sustainable recovery.

Demographics and Geographic Profile

Sabid and Anole are neighbouring villages located approximately 7 km southwest of Afgoye, separated by a narrow stretch of farmland. Before the conflict, the villages hosted an estimated 650 households in Sabid and 300 in Anole, with farming as the primary source of livelihood. Sabid and Anole are predominantly inhabited by the Hintir (Xintir) clan (approximately 90%), with minority groups—including Begedi, Banadiri, and others—comprising the remaining population.

Following intense fighting in September 2025, residents fled to Marerey and Afgoye, leaving behind all household assets, food stocks, tools, and productive resources. Sabid suffered near-total destruction, with all houses and structures damaged or destroyed. Anole experienced approximately 70% housing destruction, partly due to armed groups establishing hideouts inside civilian homes. Since the cessation of active hostilities, returns have been slow and uneven. Approximately 100 households have returned to Anole, compared with only 20 in Sabid, reflecting the severity of the destruction and ongoing security concerns.

METHODOLOGY

Between 23 and 30 November 2025, CAPs discussions were conducted in Sabid/Anole to capture community perspectives on recovery priorities, governance, security, justice, media engagement, and humanitarian interventions. The methodology combined Focus Group Discussions (FGDs) and Key Informant Interviews (KIIs) to ensure both breadth and depth of insights. Before data collection, facilitators clearly explained the purpose of the discussions and obtained informed consent from all participants. Engagements were conducted using a structured and semi-structured questionnaire, ensuring discussions remained focused, participatory, and free from interruptions.

Participants were purposively selected and organised into three distinct focus groups to ensure inclusive representation of community perspectives:

» Elders: 10 participants (6 men and 4 women)

» Women: 10 participants (all women)

» Youth: 10 participants (5 women and 5 men)

Each FGD followed a semi-structured format and lasted approximately three hours, thereby enabling in-depth dialogue, collective reflection, and agreement on key themes. To validate and triangulate findings from the FGDs, five KIIs were conducted with individuals in leadership or influential roles within the community. These included a Deputy Village Commissioner, a women's group chairlady, a representative of the Women's Association, and two respected elders and chieftains.

KIIs were conducted using a guided interview framework and lasted 30 to 60 minutes, enabling deeper exploration of governance, social dynamics, and community priorities. In total, 35 individuals participated in the assessment, comprising 21 women (60%) and 14 men (40%), reflecting a strong commitment to gender inclusion.

23 - 30 November

CAPs group discussions

Participants were divided into:

3

Focus Groups

Focus groups composition

Female

Male

Key discussion points

- Recovery efforts & humanitarian stabilisation
- Perceptions of community safety and major security threats
- Governance & local leadership

All discussions and interviews were conducted in person, recorded with participants' consent, and systematically reviewed and analysed to ensure accuracy, consistency, and reliability of findings.

FINDINGS

Security and Political Conditions

Overview and Needs of Security Actors

Despite the absence of large-scale fighting, security conditions remain fragile, marked by persistent fear of hit-and-run attacks and restricted civilian movement. Movement restrictions are particularly pronounced in Sabid due to the proximity of government forces, discouraging displaced families from returning. Compounding these challenges is the absence of civilian policing services. The local police station was destroyed during the conflict and has not yet been rehabilitated, leaving the 14th battalion of the SNA's Gorgor forces as the sole security presence in both villages, especially in Sabid.

As one participant noted, **"We do not have police in Sabid/Anole village; we only see military forces, and the government has not yet restored policing services."** The continued reliance on military forces for civilian security underscores a critical gap in stabilisation and early recovery efforts. There is a need for the SNA to bridge the community collaboration and restore policing services. Currently, the AS fighters are positioned approximately 12 km west of Sabid/Anole, along the Shabelle River.

Perceptions of Security Actors

Although AS has been pushed away from Sabid and Anole, residents continue to describe the security environment as volatile and unpredictable. Key concerns include limited freedom of movement, the absence of nighttime mobility, fear of AS retaliation, and anxiety associated with the constant presence of armed actors near civilian settlements. These dynamics have contributed to lower return rates, particularly in Sabid, and continue to constrain livelihoods, access to farmland, and social recovery.

Community views regarding a potential withdrawal of AUSSOM forces are divided. One group believes government forces could maintain basic security independently. Another group fears that government forces alone may lack the capacity to prevent AS resurgence. No divided views on the SNA nor red lines have been recorded among the participants. The respondents view the SNA positively.

Overall, findings suggest that government forces can sustain security in Sabid/Anole only if surrounding strategic locations, particularly Awdhegle and Barire, remain firmly under government control. Any loss of control in these areas would significantly increase the risk of AS's re-infiltration.

Overview of Government Structure & Representation

Sabid and Anole are predominantly inhabited by the Hintir (Xintir) clan (approximately 90%), with minority groups—including Begedi, Banadiri, and others—comprising the remaining population. Local governance structures largely reflect these clan dynamics. Decision-making authority is heavily concentrated among elders, who dominate village leadership and administrative roles. Youth participation is minimal, and women are almost entirely excluded from formal governance structures. This imbalance reflects entrenched cultural norms and highlights the need for more inclusive governance approaches as part of long-term recovery and stabilisation.

Relations between local leadership and the community are generally strong, as administrators are drawn directly from the population and often have close familial ties. Elders nominate village leaders, with approval formally granted by the Afgoye District Commissioner. This structure facilitates community-level coordination but limits broader representation. By contrast, community engagement with the FGS remains weak, particularly in relation to service delivery.

Perceptions of Government Structure & Representation

Residents expressed uncertainty about whether government services are reaching their communities directly. However, local administration maintains a functional working relationship with the FGS, particularly on security coordination. No political rivalries were reported in either village. Communities remain focused on immediate survival and recovery needs, resettlement, debris removal, and livelihood reconstruction rather than on political competition. As one participant explained, **"We are struggling just to recover and return to our homes; we are not at a point where we can think about political matters."**

Economic Conditions

Current Living Standards

Livelihoods in both villages have been severely disrupted. Before the conflict, farming was the primary source of income. Currently, access to farmland, particularly the fertile eastern and western plots used by Sabid residents, is restricted due to security concerns. Community members estimate that approximately 120 hectares of productive land remain inaccessible. Irrigation infrastructure has also been affected. AUSSOM initially restricted two key canals—Hajinur (Xaajinur) and Ibrahim Dhurow. While access to Ibrahim Dhurow has since been restored, farmers lack the financial means to reinvest in agriculture, and the river is now nearly dry. The petty trade sector has collapsed, and the destruction and closure of the bridge linking Sabid and Anole to Afgoye and Awdhegle have further isolated communities from markets, services, and economic opportunities.

NGOs Activities

No local or international NGOs have conducted humanitarian interventions in Sabid or Anole since their liberation in late August 2025. The only documented external support has been TURKSOM's rehabilitation of the bridge, which AS destroyed during the fighting.

Recovery Efforts

Although the bridge has been rehabilitated and is structurally functional, it remains closed to civilian use, severely restricting mobility and delaying recovery. Living conditions for returnees are dire. In Sabid, destruction was nearly total, whereas in Anole, approximately 70% of housing was damaged. Families whose homes were partially damaged have converted them into makeshift shelters by covering them with plastic sheets. These shelters are overcrowded, often housing three to seven households, and lack privacy, safety, and dignity. Most household assets were destroyed during the conflict. Despite these challenges, community cohesion remains strong. Residents are collectively clearing rubble, sharing limited shelter space, and pooling labour for small-scale reconstruction, thereby demonstrating resilience and mutual support.

Among strong community-led recovery efforts identified are shelter sharing and collective debris removal, as well as bridge rehabilitation by TURKSOM, despite ongoing access restrictions. Priority areas for improvement include housing reconstruction, particularly in Sabid, where destruction is near-total, emergency cash assistance and hygiene kits to address immediate household needs, and rehabilitation of water sources, as communities rely on a single hand-dug well. Additionally, agricultural inputs and conditional cash grants to restore farming livelihoods are needed, along with reconstruction of schools and Maternal and Child Health (MCH) facilities, all of which were destroyed.

IDPs Considerations

IDPs from Sabid and Anole currently residing in Marerey and Afgoye face extreme hardship. Many rely on humanitarian aid, casual labour, or begging, marking a sharp transition from self-reliant producers to dependent populations. These challenges are compounded by climate stress. The Deyr season has brought unusually low rainfall, and the river dried up more than two months earlier than usual. This early drought significantly heightens the risk of food insecurity and threatens to undermine recovery efforts in both villages and surrounding areas.

Community Perceptions

Women's participation in local governance remains extremely limited due to cultural norms. While women shoulder the bulk of household and agricultural labour, they have no formal role in decision-making. Women reported general insecurity when collecting firewood or fetching water near military bases. No gender-based violence cases were reported; however, fear of criminality persists.

Youth, particularly young men, express fear of being perceived as AS affiliates, resulting in harassment and insecurity. The absence of civilian policing and the presence of armed actors near homes exacerbate these concerns.

Minority and dominant groups reported similar experiences of hardship and restricted movement following the conflict. Movement restrictions, canal closures, and the absence of night-time travel were repeatedly cited as major constraints on daily life and recovery.

Justice Systems

Formal justice mechanisms are currently inaccessible due to the destruction of infrastructure and the lack of police presence. As a result, communities rely almost entirely on the traditional Xeer system, which has governed dispute resolution for generations. Minority groups, in particular, feel marginalised within formal government systems, reinforcing reliance on Xeer as the most accessible and effective justice mechanism. Elder councils have 18 members in Sabid and 9 in Anole and continue to serve as the primary authorities for conflict resolution and communal decision-making.

Media and Sources of Information

Sabid and Anole lack access to television and internet services due to poverty and connectivity constraints. Most residents rely on FM radio stations based in Mogadishu, such as Radio Mogadishu and Goal FM. Mobile phones are limited but widely used by household heads, primarily for financial transactions, which have largely supplanted physical currency in the region. Mobile phone calls remain the primary means of accessing and sharing information. Communities rely on trusted individuals to verify and disseminate news, particularly related to security threats and service availability. As one participant explained, **"If we see security threats, we call the community and warn them through mobile phones."**

CONCLUSION & RECOMMENDATIONS

The assessment findings confirm that Sabid and Anole remain in a fragile post-conflict transition, characterised by extensive physical destruction, persistent insecurity, and stalled recovery. While limited returns, primarily in Anole, signal cautious confidence among some displaced families, the overall pace of resettlement remains slow. Severe shelter destruction, restricted movement, lack of civilian policing, limited access to farmland, and early-onset drought conditions continue to undermine safety, livelihoods, and basic dignity for returnees.

Security gains achieved through military operations have not yet translated into civilian stabilisation. The absence of functional police services, continued movement restrictions around military bases, and fears of AS retaliation contribute to widespread insecurity, particularly at night, and discourage broader

returns. At the same time, weak government service delivery and minimal engagement beyond security coordination have eroded community trust in formal institutions.

Economically, communities have shifted from productive, farming-based livelihoods to survival-oriented coping mechanisms. The continued closure of the rehabilitated bridge, the destruction of irrigation systems, the lack of agricultural inputs, and the near-total loss of housing, especially in Sabid, have compounded poverty and prolonged dependency. Early drying of the river during the Deyr season further heightens the risk of food insecurity and threatens prospects for sustainable recovery.

Despite these challenges, community resilience remains a critical asset. Strong social cohesion, reliance on traditional governance structures, and the continued use of the Xeer justice system have helped preserve social order and mutual support in the absence of formal systems. Residents continue to share shelter, clear debris collectively, and support one another through informal networks, demonstrating commitment to recovery even in the absence of external assistance.

However, the near-total absence of humanitarian and early recovery interventions represents a critical gap. Without timely, coordinated support, including shelter reconstruction, restoration of water and irrigation systems, livelihood assistance, civilian policing, and reopening of critical infrastructure, Sabid and Anole risk prolonged displacement, deepening vulnerability, and renewed instability.

In conclusion, urgent, multi-sectoral recovery interventions are essential to consolidate security gains, restore basic services, and enable safe, dignified, and sustainable returns. Addressing immediate humanitarian needs while investing in inclusive governance, livelihood restoration, and civilian protection will be critical to preventing further deterioration and supporting long-term stabilisation in Sabid and Anole.

To consolidate stabilisation gains in Sabid and Anole, a coordinated, multi-sectoral recovery response is urgently required:

Emergency Shelter and Housing Reconstruction:

» Immediate action is required to address the severe shelter crisis, particularly in Sabid, where destruction is nearly total. Humanitarian agencies, in coordination with the Ministry of Humanitarian Affairs and Disaster Management (MoHADM) and district authorities, should provide temporary shelter kits including plastic sheeting, poles, and basic toolkits—to reduce overcrowding and improve living conditions for returnees.

Water, Sanitation, and Hygiene (WASH):

» Given acute water shortages and reliance on a single hand-dug well, WASH actors working with local authorities and community water committees should rehabilitate existing wells and establish additional emergency water points. The distribution of hygiene kits and water containers to returning households is critical for reducing public health risks.

Livelihoods and Agricultural Recovery:

» Restoring livelihoods is essential to reducing dependency and enabling sustainable returns. Livelihoods and food security actors, in collaboration with the Ministry of Agriculture and local administrations, should provide agricultural inputs such as seeds, tools, and irrigation equipment alongside conditional cash grants to enable farmers to rehabilitate their land. Key actors could be the Ministry of Agriculture, FAO, NGOs and district authorities.

Bridge Access and Civilian Mobility:

» The continued closure of the rehabilitated bridge remains a major barrier to recovery. Government authorities, supported by security actors and stabilisation partners, should conduct a joint security assessment to reopen the bridge for controlled civilian use through phased, monitored access. There is a need to reopen the bridge in phases and monitor civilian access. Lead actors such as the Ministry of Interior and the local district administration, and support organisations such as the SNA, AUSSOM, and stabilisation partners, could be vital.

Security and Local Governance:

» To transition from military control to civilian stabilisation, the FGS through the Ministry of Internal Security and Somali Police Force—should prioritise the rehabilitation of the destroyed police station and restoration of civilian policing services in Sabid/Anole. At the community level, Community Safety Committees comprising elders, women, youth, and minority representatives should be established to facilitate information-sharing and improve coordination with security actors. International partners should support conflict-sensitive and civilian protection training for SNA units operating near residential areas to reduce tensions and enhance accountability.

Social Protection and Humanitarian Assistance:

» Immediate emergency cash assistance is needed for returnee households that have lost assets and lack income sources. Cash-based interventions should be coordinated through humanitarian actors and aligned with national social protection frameworks where feasible. At the same time, IDPs from Sabid and Anole currently residing in Marerey and Afgoye should continue to receive food assistance, rental support, and livelihood recovery assistance until conditions allow for safe and voluntary return.

Inclusive Governance and Community Engagement:

» Recovery efforts should promote inclusive participation in local decision-making. NGOs and governance-focused partners should facilitate community dialogue forums that encourage meaningful involvement of women and youth in planning and prioritisation processes. Support should also be provided to help local administrations function more effectively by connecting elders' councils to district-level governance, thereby improving coordination, accountability, and access to government services.

Justice and Social Cohesion:

» As security conditions improve, justice sector actors should support the gradual restoration of formal justice services, including the deployment of mobile courts where feasible. In the interim, programmes should strengthen the traditional Xeer system by providing elders with training in inclusive dispute resolution, protection principles, and the rights of women and minority groups. Establish referral pathways between customary and formal justice systems.

Mine and Explosive Remnants of War (ERW) Clearance:

» Given the conflict context and return of civilians, specialised actors such as UNMAS and accredited mine action NGOs should conduct an urgent assessment and clearance of explosive remnants of war in residential areas, farmland, and key access routes. Community members should also receive risk education training to promote safe behaviour and establish mechanisms for reporting suspected explosive hazards.

Communication and Early Warning Systems:

» Finally, to improve access to timely information, partners should establish basic community communication systems, such as solar-powered radios, shared mobile phones, or notice boards. Training community focal points, particularly youth and elders, on early warning and rapid reporting mechanisms will strengthen local preparedness and improve responses to security threats and humanitarian alerts.